The growing interlocking between the countryside and the market economy seemed to have missed him altogether. And yet, I was inclined to give him the benefit of the doubt—if he could show the same fervour in transforming his ideas into a concrete plan of action, then we were really witnessing the start of a new innings in Indian politics.

In the next two years—2007 to 2009—Rahul Gandhi kept up this image of being a youth leader who stood for ‘change’. NSUI conventions were organized across the country where Rahul Gandhi would reiterate his desire to bring in a new order of politics by ridding his party of the ‘nomination’ culture. Images of enthusiastic students greeting him were seen on TV screens. His critics called it a ‘discovery of India’ tour, suggesting that Rahul Gandhi was still struggling to get acquainted with the real India. When he visited a Dalit home for a night, Mayawati accused him of ‘opportunism’ and a desire to pander to Dalit voters. ‘He has used a special soap and incense to purify himself,’ she thundered at a rally in April 2008. The visits may have smacked of tokenism, perhaps even of poverty tourism, but at least a Gandhi finally seemed to be readying himself for a fierce political battle.

It didn’t take long, though, for the bubble to burst. On a visit to Mumbai, a few Youth Congress members expressed a desire to meet me. I asked them about the electoral process that had been initiated in the organization. ‘What elections, sir, everything is being fixed and a lot of money is changing hands. You must expose it,’ was their plea. Apparently, the main candidates in the fray were all sons of leading Congress politicians from the state. Eventually, the Maharashtra State Youth Congress ‘elected’ as its president Vishwajeet Kadam, son of a powerful state minister who owned a chain of private education institutes. The pattern was repeated in other states with the children of top politicians dominating key positions. When it came to Lok Sabha seats too, most of the younger candidates had family links with senior leaders. Attempts at fostering inner-party democracy could not break the well-entrenched cliques of patronage within the party system.

In a sense, Rahul Gandhi was a prisoner of the very system that had spawned him. Once the top leadership of the party observes the dynastical